

Match the verb to what the design identifies

A bounded sentence is stronger than an unsupported causal headline

	Defensible wording	Wording to avoid
Cross-sectional	is associated with	causes
Longitudinal	precedes or predicts	drives disease
Mediation / MR	is consistent with an indirect or genetically proxied effect	proves mediation or causality
Human intervention	changed under the assigned intervention	the microbiome alone caused the change
Experimental transfer	transferred a phenotype in the model	must cause the same phenotype in humans
Defined rescue	restored a phenotype under controlled conditions	is universally protective
Mechanistic chain	acts through the specified pathway in the tested system	is the only mechanism